

many times we are right, and this serves us well. Like when I experience hunger pangs in my body, I don't need to go through a whole exercise of "being curious" about what it means. I have lived long enough to know what hunger feels like, and I'm wise enough to know the best pathway forward is butter-frying a hot dog on the stove and chowing down on that bad boy.

But where true introspection is needed and would serve us well, we're sometimes afraid to look. Whether it's thinking the worst of yourself, or concern that you won't know how to fix whatever you may find broken, it can be easier to ignore it and continue existing as you were. You also may avoid getting curious with yourself because you *do* know what you will find, and the weight of it feels overwhelming. Financial anxieties and all the "shoulding" and "musting" about career, family life, housing, transportation, or investing can lead to feeling stuck, not knowing where to go next, and not wanting to engage with any of it. Not to mention if you've never seen good examples of what it's like to manage money well or save and spend with purpose.

This was the case for our friend Christine. Money was never talked about growing up, and credit cards were the only way she knew how to pay for stuff. By the time she graduated college, she not only had \$38,000 in student loan debt but \$14,000 of credit card debt on top of it. When she and her boyfriend started getting serious about marriage, she had a feeling of dread when they brought up finances. She had a decent job but still felt as though everything she wanted for her future was permanently out of reach. With her credit card and student loan debt still looming, she would get this sick, sinking feeling whenever she thought about how impossible buying a house or affording beautiful international trips felt. Things she thought she "should" do, things she saw her friends doing. Christine tried talking with her parents, but their philosophy with money was "It will all work out." Chatting with friends seemed wrong because some of them were in worse financial predicaments than her. Even her therapist was at a loss for what to do when her worries were disproportionate to her very "average" circumstances. With no real guidance, all Christine could do was ignore the issue. Unfortunately, disregarding what was happening and how she felt about it never got the debt paid, or removed the shame of spending, or even got her close to what she actually wanted to do with her money. Thankfully, Christine's story didn't end there. Eventually she was able to face the ever-